final one, the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement (BECA), was signed in October 2020. Taken together these allow for access to each other's intelligence, secure communications, logistical facilities upon request, and US surveillance systems. After a fairly tepid Indian response to the US's and Japan's Free and Open Indo-Pacific, Delhi has warmed up to both the FOIP and the associated Quad. It now agrees that the meetings of the FOIP and the Quad with Australia, Japan, and the US should be held at the ministerial level. It has also finally invited Australia to the Malabar naval exercises along with Japan and the US. The Ladakh crisis and a desire to signal greater closeness to the US certainly played a role in tipping India over into inviting the Australian Navy.

If India has been slow to align with the US, this is because it has wanted to avoid provoking China and alienating Russia beyond a point. After the Ladakh crisis, the reluctance to irk China has diminished considerably. On the other hand, keeping Russia friendly is crucial. Russian arms, particularly major weapon systems, are still the preferred option for the Indian military. Besides, in Delhi's view, Moscow must be stopped from going completely over to Beijing's side. However, in the long term, given the power gap with China and the several confrontations at the border since 2013, India has little option but to partner the US. Indian decision-makers know that the US will stay away from being directly involved in an India–China fight, but they are counting on American intelligence, arms, military technologies, and diplomatic support to enhance Indian material capabilities as also its bargaining power with China.

Predictably, China is suspicious of India's partnership with the US. The standard Chinese view is that the two powers are teaming up to 'contain' China's rise and that India's talk of 'strategic autonomy' and 'non-alignment' is just that – mere talk. Delhi is in fact working with the US and other powers in Asia including the Quad powers to 'encircle' China. Chinese views are not uniform. An alternative perspective in China is that Delhi's robust sense of independence, plus the contradictions in the India–US relationship over Iran, Russian arms, trade, and immigration, will limit its drift towards Washington. There is also a recognition that Chinese